

# Prelude: Both Sides of the Coin

A glass and steel tower reflected back the early morning sunlight glimmering out on the choppy waters of the bay. High on the 30th story, the lord of the tower stood with his hands clasped together at his back, posture stately and rigid. In the office behind him, vassals quietly filled the coffee carafe and laid out assorted fruit and pastries. The lord of the tower longed for *syrniki* with jam in lieu of the sticky danishes and too soon stale doughnuts, but he kept these thoughts to himself in front of the staff. Wanting was a weakness in and of itself, and one did one's best to avoid weakness where others may observe it.

A few lesser lords and ladies came with paperwork, which the lord of the tower signed in a neat hand, lacking any flourish. Severance packages, cost breakdowns, and financial reports — dull, dull, and duller still. Dame Amici held out a beautifully-illuminated scroll ceding four blocks around Collington Square Park to Viscount Pomerain de Beaumayne. The lord of the tower wrinkled his nose in distaste as he scrawled his full name and title in the most ostentatious fashion he could manage.

"Oh, don't make such a face, Sevastyan," came his sister's voice behind him. She'd been the one who insisted on all the silk rugs. Baroness Zhanna Ved'ma of House Varich preferred to have her presence remain unannounced until she chose to reveal it.

"So kind of you to worry about my face, so that I may focus on more important matters, *Zhannochka*," said Baron Sevastyan.

Baroness Zhanna *tsked*. "*Nevazhno*, brother. I can see your deeply important work takes precedence over a conversation with your only sister, whatever the topic."

Baron Sevastyan waved Dame Amici and her scroll away. He briefly pinched the bridge of his nose, cursing their mother for the inconvenience of burdening him with a younger sister.

"It is done now, *Zhannochka*," he said. "What do you need?"

"I thought you might wish to know that the security upgrades on the vault are complete, but if I am taking up too much of your time..."

Baron Sevastyan smiled at his sister, thin lips barely revealing his teeth. "My time is yours, sister." Without turning away from the window and its expanding sunlight, he clapped his hands once and said, "Leave."